

Monitoring smouldering myeloma

Myeloma with no symptoms is also called smouldering or asymptomatic myeloma. You may have active monitoring, which means delaying treatment until it is needed.

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What is smouldering myeloma?

[Myeloma](#) with no symptoms is also called smouldering or asymptomatic myeloma. The plasma cells show abnormal changes on blood tests, but they usually do not cause symptoms.

You may not need treatment straight away. There is no strong evidence that having treatment at this stage will help. Instead, your cancer team may suggest active monitoring.

What is active monitoring?

Active monitoring may sometimes be called active surveillance or watch and wait. This means you do not have treatment until it is needed.

You will have [blood samples](#) and some other tests every few months. If tests show the myeloma is progressing or you develop symptoms, your doctor will talk to you about starting [treatment](#).

Some people may feel worried or anxious about not starting treatment straight away. If you are worried about not having treatment, you might find these tips helpful:

- Make sure you understand why active monitoring is recommended. If you have any concerns, talk to your doctor or nurse.
- Use your time to do things you enjoy, and to get as fit and healthy as you can.
- Try to focus on the present, rather than what might happen in the future.
- [Share your feelings](#). You can do this by talking to family and friends, joining a support group or [online forum](#), or by keeping a journal.

Although active monitoring can be difficult to adjust to at first, many people find it gets easier as time goes on. We have more information about the [emotional effects of cancer](#).

Some people may be offered treatment for smouldering myeloma, but only as part of a [clinical trial](#). Your myeloma team can give you more information about clinical trials if needed.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our myeloma information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

Hughes D, Yong K, Ramasamy K, et al. Diagnosis and management of smouldering myeloma: A British Society for Haematology Good Practice Paper. Br J Haematol. 2024;204(4):1193-1206. Available from: www.doi.org/10.1111/bjh.19333

Sive J, Cuthill K, Hunter H, et al. Guidelines on the diagnosis, investigation and initial treatment of myeloma: a British Society for Haematology/UK Myeloma Forum Guideline. Br J Haematol. 2021;193(2):245-268. Available from: www.doi.org/10.1111/bjh.17410

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help